

Buying MORE TIME

Pakistan admits to just about enough on the Mumbai attacks for India to put on hold tough options including a military strike

By Raj Chengappa

It was perhaps the most important reply that Pakistan officially gave to India in recent times. With relations tumbling to a dangerous low after the Mumbai attacks and India's patience running thin after it submitted a detailed dossier in January elaborating the links the terrorists had with Pakistan, Islamabad was faced with daunting choices. If Pakistan denied all links and brushed aside the evidence, India would use it as an excuse to exercise hard options including a possible military strike and justify it to the international community. If it yielded too much, then the Indian Government would double the pressure and demand the maximum including dismantling all terrorist infrastructure and extraditing the accused to face trial in Indian courts.

So in the past month, Pakistan floated several trial balloons to gauge how both India and the international community would respond before giving a formal reply. Its spokespersons initially dismissed the Indian evidence as inadequate and totally denied involvement of Pakistani elements. When there was an outcry, Pakistan made token arrests of Lashkar-e-

Toiba leaders accused of masterminding the Mumbai attacks and cracked down on their front organisation the Jamaat-ud-Dawa. But followed it up quickly with leaks that the conspiracy was not hatched in Pakistan. It then dragged its feet over giving a reply to the Indian dossier after setting a deadline of 30 days. The visit of Richard Holbrooke, the new US special representative, appears to have put pressure on Pakistan to stop the dithering as did President Barack Obama's remark that there are "safe havens in Pakistan" for terrorists.

When Rehman Malik, Pakistan prime minister's adviser on interior affairs, finally announced the outcome of his country's investigations into the matter, the approach was clear. Pakistan had admitted to just about enough so that India would have to pause and put on hold any of the hard options it planned including severing diplomatic relations. Also to pacify the international community and get them to believe, as Malik says, "that Pakistan is serious and sincere in our investigations."

So in a first, Malik admitted that "Indian evidence was credible" and

PAKISTAN'S MALIK WITH THE REPORT; (RIGHT) TAJ HOTEL AND KASAB (EXTREME RIGHT)

that "some part of the conspiracy related to the Mumbai attacks was planned in Pakistan." He then mentioned nine individuals believed to be responsible for it in Pakistan of which, he claimed, six had been arrested and FIRs lodged against them. Significantly, Malik admitted that some of them had links to the Lashkar but avoided the issue of state actors being involved.

Stating that the attacks had wider international connections, Malik said Pakistan investigators had traced cyber links including money transactions for the attacks to contacts in Spain, Austria, Italy, Russia, the USA and a Gulf country. Pakistan had apprehended one of the suspects, Javed Iqbal from Barcelona, who had provided clues to others. Pakistan would now be justified in calling for an international investigation into the links exposed by its investigations thereby buying it lot more time.

In what is seen as an attempt to further prolong the investigations,

